freedom itself. And the more big industry spreads the less can small-scale village industries compete with it. They may have some chance of survival under a socialist system, but none under capitalism, and even under socialism they can only exist as cottage industries specialising in particular goods which are not manufactured on a mass scale.

Some Congress leaders are frightened of industrialisation, and imagine that the present-day troubles of the industrial countries are due to mass production. That is a strange misreading of the situation.[1] If the masses lack anything, is it bad to produce it in sufficient quantities for them? Is it preferable for them to continue in want rather than have mass production? The fault obviously is not in the production but in the folly and inadequacy of the distributive system.

Another difficulty which the promoters of village industries have to face is the dependence of our agriculture on the world market. The peasant is forced to grow commercial crops and to depend on world prices. While these prices vary he has to pay his rent or revenue in hard cash. He has to raise this money somehow, or at any rate he tries to do so, and so he sows the crops which he thinks will bring him the best price. He cannot afford to grow what he himself needs to make himself and his family self-sufficient even in the matter of food.

In recent years the fall in agricultural prices of most food grains and other articles suddenly led millions of the peasantry, especially in the U.P. and Behar, to cultivate sugar-cane. A tariff on sugar had resulted in sugar factories cropping up like mushrooms, and sugar-cane was in great demand. But the supply was soon far in excess of the demand, and the factory owners cruelly exploited the peasantry, and the price fell.

These few considerations and a host of others seem to me to exclude the possibility or the desirability of any narrow autarchichal solution of our agrarian and industrial problems. Indeed they affect every phase of our national life. We cannot take refuge in vague and emotional phrases, but must face these facts and adapt ourselves to them, so that we may become the subjects of history instead of being its helpless objects.

[1] Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel speaking at Ahmedabad on January 3, 1935: "True socialism lies in the development of village industries. We do not want to reproduce in our country the chaotic conditions prevalent in the Western countries consequent on mass-production"